Diploma in UX Design

UX Specialist Review

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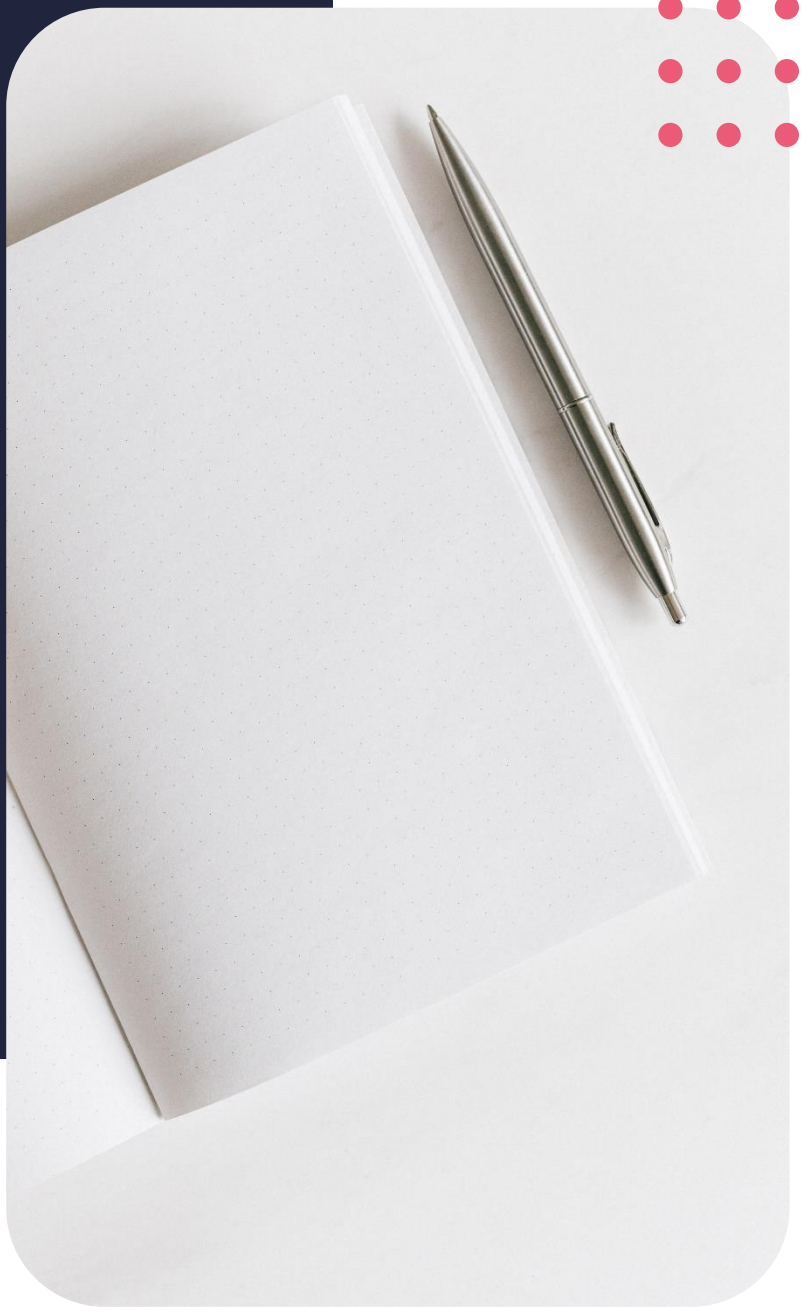

Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Understand a UX specialist review
- Steps to conduct a UX specialist review
- Jacob Nielsen's general principles of UI

Introduction

Would it not be great if you can immediately contribute to the field of UX just after your 2nd lesson? This is exactly what we will be exploring today and even though becoming successful in UX takes time, there are some basics that you are not even aware of you already know. You are already a user of user interfaces. With just a little awareness of the UX principles and a useful framework to formally evaluate what you see on the screen; you can immediately start to make insightful observations and recommendations that will increase the efficiency of designs dramatically. You can be almost certain that after this lesson you will be able to provide advice to app, website, or digital product managers to dramatically improve the user experience.

Understand a UX specialist review

What is a UX specialist review?

UX specialist reviews are an excellent way to get feedback on a design or prototype, and recommendations on how it can be improved. It is a cost-effective manner to improve usability in a very short time. It is much faster and cheaper compared to user testing.

Unfortunately, it doesn't replace user-testing because it is essential to get feedback from user-testing as well. It should be done for evaluating and quality control for any design or prototype, ideally in combination with user-testing.

Why conduct a UX specialist review?

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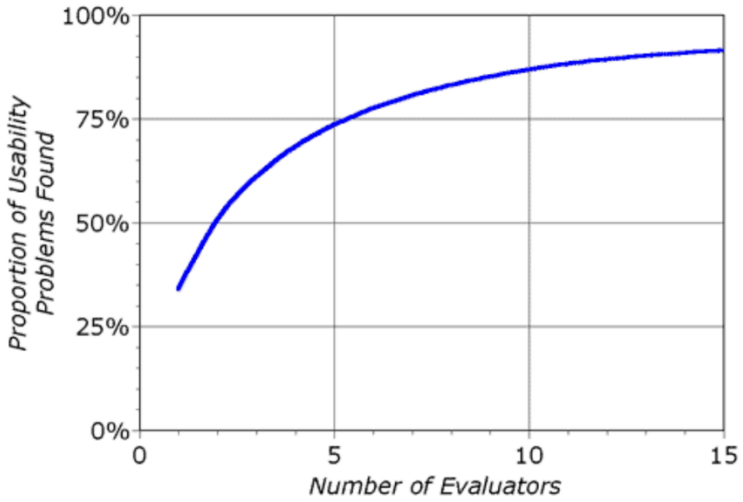
Who conducts a UX specialist review?

A UX specialist review can be conducted by anyone with experience of being a user of digital products. It can also be conducted by someone who knows about the basic principles of UX. All digital-savvy persons comply with the first criterion because they have experience with using digital products. However, they don't know the theoretical principles of UX. They can however participate in user-testing, and their thoughts are crucial to get and improve UX ideas. To do a specialist review or heuristic evaluation, you will have to understand these heuristics or best practice principles of UX design. The best persons to do UX specialist reviews are UX designers who developed a lot of successful prototypes and did a lot of user research. This allows them to have a strong sense of intuition about what will work, and how UX principles can be applied. A strong background in psychology and consumer research is also very helpful.

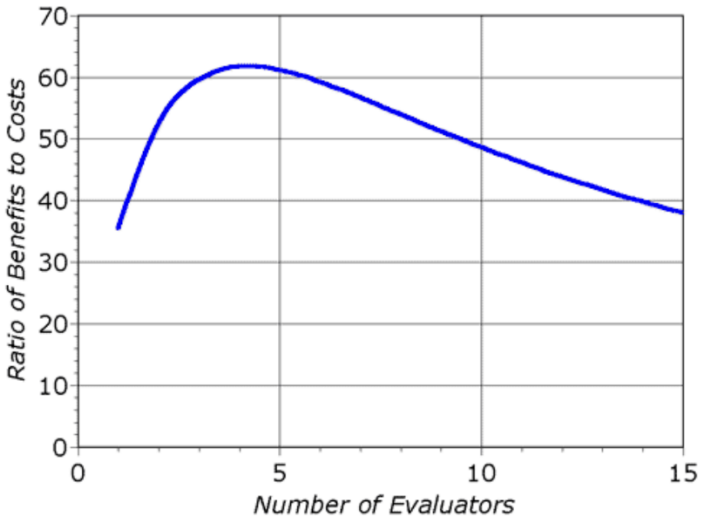
How big is the team conducting this review?

The next question is how many persons should conduct a specialist review on a particular prototype or design? One person is often sufficient, or at least better than no one. In general, a single reviewer of average ability can identify about a third of all potential usability issues. However, a single highly experienced UX researcher who conducted many user tests and UX audits, combined with a good knowledge of UX design theory, can identify as much as 90% of usability issues.

This graph, based on research by Nielsen and Landauer (1993), indicates that one can expect a single UX evaluator to identify a third of all usability issues of a design or prototype, two evaluators to identify half of all usability issues, three evaluators about 60%, four evaluators about 70%, five evaluators about 74%, ten evaluators about 86% and 15 evaluators about 92% of usability issues. You can see that the more evaluators you use, the more usability issues are identified, but it is not a linear relationship. Initially, each new evaluator finds a lot more usability issues, but from about five evaluators onwards, each additional evaluator finds fewer additional usability issues. This phenomenon is known as diminishing returns.



Because adding more evaluators comes at an increasing cost, there is a point where the number of evaluators is optimal given the number of usability issues that are identified. This graph shows how many times the benefits are greater than the costs regarding the number of evaluators conducting a UX audit or heuristic evaluation. Based on the results from Nielsen and Landauer's research, it is thus ideal to use four evaluators, since the benefits of improving the usability of your digital product may be 62 times greater than the costs of hiring those four evaluators.



I don't have access to 4 evaluators, what should I do?

Unfortunately, in practice, it is not easy to access the services of 4 evaluators. In such a case, a practical solution is to let every design or prototype be formally evaluated by one highly experienced UX specialist, who may be contracted from outside if such a skilled person is not available within the organisation. Then, let the report of the evaluator be reviewed by three UX persons within the organisation, to add their comments or to discuss findings further. These persons may be UX designers, UX researchers, UX content writers or product managers. This is also a good way to transfer skills from the highly skilled UX reviewer to the rest of the team.

Steps to conduct a UX specialist review

It is essential to conduct a UX specialist review in order to determine the usability and effectiveness of the digital product. An effective way to tackle this process is to break it down into digestible steps. Not conducting a review will leave room for issues that your client's digital product might face. The following steps will guide you in conducting an effective US specialist review.

- Identify business objectives
- Understand your users' needs
- Analyse data and the outcome
- Identify possible issues
- Provide actionable solutions and opportunities
- Review & prepare report

Identify business objectives

When working as an in-house UX designer, you might already be familiar with the company's objectives regarding the digital product. However, consulting a client, you will need to identify and understand the business objectives before moving forward. An effective way to identify the business objectives is by conducting a survey or interviews with the relevant stakeholders of the company. The survey or interview's aim is to not only determine what the digital product does well but also determine the weak points of the digital product.

By identifying the business objectives, it will be easier for the UX designer to understand the business goals. Remember to share your results with your client to ensure that both parties agree on the business objectives.

Understand your users' needs

The advantage of gathering information regarding the business objectives as we did in the first step is that it will provide you with insight into understanding the users' needs as well. Alternatively, you can create fictional user-profiles known as user personas that will assist in understanding your users better. The user personas will represent a variety of different people that will utilise your digital product.

Your research in this step can include anything between 5 and more people, depending on the amount of time you have available. At this stage, provide your user personas with the digital product and conduct a survey to determine their experience and expectations in using the product. It is essential that you ensure each user persona follows the same setup and procedure to guarantee unity throughout the evaluation.

Analyse data and the outcome

Quantitative data can be collected with a data analysis tool like Google Analytics. Analytic and measuring tools allow UX designers some valuable insights into who is using the digital product, why they are using it and what they might be doing while using the product. Other UX analytic and metrics tools you can consider using include KISSmetrics, Crazy Egg, Good Data, Hotjar and Mix Panel.

Identify possible issues

Based on the research, analysis and data gathered in the previous steps, the UX designer should have a good idea of possible issues that might jeopardise the user experience. Things that should be considered here include the responsiveness of the product, message clarity as well as accessibility.

Responsiveness relates to how the product will be viewed on different digital devices. The digital product's design should flow and adapt to the screen to provide a seamless and user-friendly experience.

After the layout and responsiveness of the digital product have been evaluated, possible issues regarding the clarity of the message should be examined. Type hierarchy plays an important role in this regard. Type hierarchy is the principle based on the most important text is seen first, followed by the 2nd most important information and then the rest of the information. Look at it from this perspective: your heading is the most important text, followed by your subheading and then the body copy. Make sure that it remains in this order and that consistency is also maintained. Other issues that can crop up here include large chunks of text, which can be overwhelming, overpowering buttons that draw away from your important elements, and confusing instructional text.

When it comes to the accessibility of your product, is it inclusive? This means, does your product cater to its target audience, including those with disabilities? A great tool that can be used to identify possible accessibility issues is Google's Lighthouse.

Provide actionable solutions and opportunities

Based on the issues identified in the previous step, you will now determine how to action solutions and possible opportunities to enhance the ultimate user experience. Since identifying issues goes hand-in-hand with seeking solutions, it is assumed that you have proactively investigated possible solutions and opportunities. UX designers are creative problem-solvers, and this should be something that should be fostered if you are considering a career in UX design.

Review and prepare report

Compile your findings and prepare your final UX report based on all the information gathered in the previous steps. These findings, as well as possible recommendations, should be presented to your client and the rest of the team that worked on this project. Your information should be presented in a document that clearly states the findings, possible issues and solutions as well as outcomes.

An evaluation template can be utilised to list this information. The template will not be set however and will be adapted depending on each project. You can find a template to utilise in your bonus material, however, please note that it should be used as a guideline and that you will most certainly need to customise it for each project.

During this course, we will investigate these steps in more detail since this is how you will tackle any UX project from now on. It is an essential process to understand and follow, so if you feel that you still don't grasp it, take heart that this was only an introduction.

Did you know?

UX design is much more than designing websites to be intuitive, you will need to consider the design of mobile applications as well. Did you know that mobile phone users open their phone every 5,6 minutes of the day! We are nowadays using our phones a lot more than computers, so make sure that when you consider the use of a digital product, that you take your mobile users into great consideration as well.

Jacob Nielsen's general principles of user interaction

With a trained eye, you can look at websites, apps or software user interfaces and spot whether it is likely to be user-friendly or not. All you need to know is the basic principles of good user interface design and apply them to what you see on the screen. There are several frameworks or checklists of good practices for user interface design. The most common one is Jakob Nielsen's 10 general principles for interaction design. Other frameworks, including Jon Yablonski's 'Laws of UX' will also be discussed in future lessons.

The origin of these principles

Jakob Nielsen's 10 general principles for interaction design is a list of ten "heuristics" or broad rules of thumb for designing digital products that are easy and efficient to use. It was originally developed in the early 1990s to evaluate software interfaces as part of the computer science subject of 'human-computer interaction'. Although it was developed three decades ago, it was so thoroughly researched and the scope was broad enough for it to be applied to any digital interface, including mobile apps, websites, software, smartwatches, game consoles and any other digital or electronic interface or system with which a human must interact.

Overview of Jakob Nielsen's ten principles

The **first** principle or heuristic is **visibility of system status**. This relates to the fact that a user should always be able to determine where they are in the process and whether their interactions are effective or not. For example, a progress indicator when you download software should show that the download is taking place at the moment and how long it will take. Another example include after the click of a button, you should see the state of the button change. Something like a ripple effect or a new screen to indicate that the button click or press was indeed successful. Failing to include this simple visibility experience will make the user feel the need to press the button again until you eventually see some reaction.

The **second** principle is **match between system and the real world**. This means that the user interface elements should look and feel natural. For example, a button should look more or less like a real button that can be pressed, a warning message should be red or orange, or an icon representing a bar or saloon should look like a wine or beer glass.

The **third** principle is **user control and freedom**. A need to feel in control and free to explore the system, going back or forth as they please, without getting lost or fearing that something terrible may happen if they make a mistake or pressing a button. This is where a back button, undo and redo buttons, or previews may come in handy.

The **fourth** principle for good UX is **consistency and standards**. This refers to following generally accepted and familiar designs and patterns, sticking to components and design elements that users are familiar with. For example, link text should be blue or underlined, back button to the left, and a red colour should indicate danger or a warning. It should do what users expect it should do based on their past experience.

The **fifth** principle is **error prevention**. The system must make it easy to take the right action, and assist users not to make mistakes. For example, if the user type in an account number that does not match the account name, give them a warning that they may be about to pay into the wrong account. Or if they enter a shop into a navigation app but will only arrive after it closed, tell them so.

The **sixth** principle is **recognition rather than recall**. It is much easier for people to recognise a word or element if they see it amongst a few options than to recall it simply from memory. For example, if you ask a user what airline they prefer to travel with, give them a selection box with the relevant airlines to choose from incorporating their logos, instead of expecting the user to type it out from memory. Alternatively, provide a save button rather than forcing the user to memorise a keyboard shortcut to save their work.

The **seventh** principle is **flexibility and efficiency of use**. The app should be easy to use for beginners, but also quick to expert users who already know how to use it and use it mainly for specific purposes, therefore will expect shortcuts for increased productivity or personalisation of the screen layout and menu items so they can quickly get to what they always do.

The **eighth** principle is **aesthetic and minimalist design**. This refers to the need for a beautiful interface because attractive interfaces are more engaging and pleasant to use. It should also have a clean and simplistic design enabling the user to easily navigate. A complex, cluttered interface divert attention away from the most relevant content on the screen, causing mental fatigue. We will learn how to effectively apply the elements and principles of design later in this course.

The **ninth** principle is **helping users to recognise, diagnose, and recover from errors**. Error prevention as discussed earlier is very important, but users will still make mistakes. As a UX designer, you must be able to assist them to realise that they made a mistake and to correct it easily. For example, if the user made a spelling mistake, underline it in red and suggest a word or two which represents the likely correctly spelt word. Or if the user tries to open a file in an unsupported file format, explain in easily understood language that the file cannot be opened because it is saved as a type of file that currently installed software cannot read. Solve this issue by suggesting an app or software that can be installed to open the file.

The **tenth** principle is **help and documentation**. Whenever a user may not know what to do or how to accomplish their goal or solve their problem, help should be available. Help can be in the form of live chat, a number to call, a tooltip, a frequently asked questions section, how-to articles, in-context help messages or other means to get a solution.

Lesson challenge

Considering the principle of match between system and the real world, I would like you to take your book and create 3 different icons for elementary, secondary, and high school. If you had to put these institutions into an icon or symbol, what would they look like?

These icons should represent each of these institutions. Write down the reason on why you chose these specific icons and test these icons with friends and family to determine if your users will be able to recognise and match these icons to the real world.

You can either draw these icons in your sketch book or digital – which ever means you are comfortable with. Share your design on your favourite social media platform using the #Uxicondesign and provide some reasoning for your design choice.

Conclusion

These UX principles should become second nature to you as they will be applied to every single UX project that you may tackle in future.

In this lesson, we learned how to look at user interfaces and use a framework of UX principles to determine their user-friendliness and efficiency. We also examined the steps to conduct a UX review. There are several frameworks that can be used to determine a digital product's effective usability. One such framework, namely Jakob Nielsen's Ten Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design was briefly investigated. Stay tuned as we delve deeper into this framework in our next lesson.

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